

Within months of the construction of Chicago's first neighborhood parks, the D.H. Burnham Company included the new park form in its plan for San Francisco. This set a precedent for the development of neighborhood parks throughout the United States. The immediate success of the South Park

Commission's small parks encouraged the fledgling Playground Association of America to hold its first annual convention in Chicago in 1907. Prior to the meeting, President Theodore Roosevelt had issued a public statement suggesting that municipalities send representatives to the conference: "...to see the magnificent system that Chicago has erected in its South Park district, one of the most notable civic achievements of any American city."⁵

These parks were often the only source of such services as bathing facilities, hot meals sold at cost, English lessons for adults and children, vocational training, recreation and athletics, and social events. However, the magnitude of their significance was even greater. They were the clean neighborhood places where one might rest after a 12-hour day of factory work and enjoy a pleasing landscape. I believe that we can gain inspiration by understanding the history of the neighborhood parks. They reflect a period in which all levels of society were united in an effort to make the city a better place to live.

Walter Netsch

¹The terms "pleasure grounds" and "breathing spaces" or "breathing spots" appear frequently in numerous articles in the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clipping Volumes, 1901-1908, held by the Chicago Park District Special Collections. "Pleasure grounds" referred to the existing parks of the South, West, and Lincoln Park Commissions. "Breathing spaces" or "breathing spots" generally referred to any of the new parks in the working class neighborhoods.

²Henry Smith, *Chicago's Great Century, 1833-1933* (Chicago: Consolidated Publishers, Inc., 1936), p. 82.

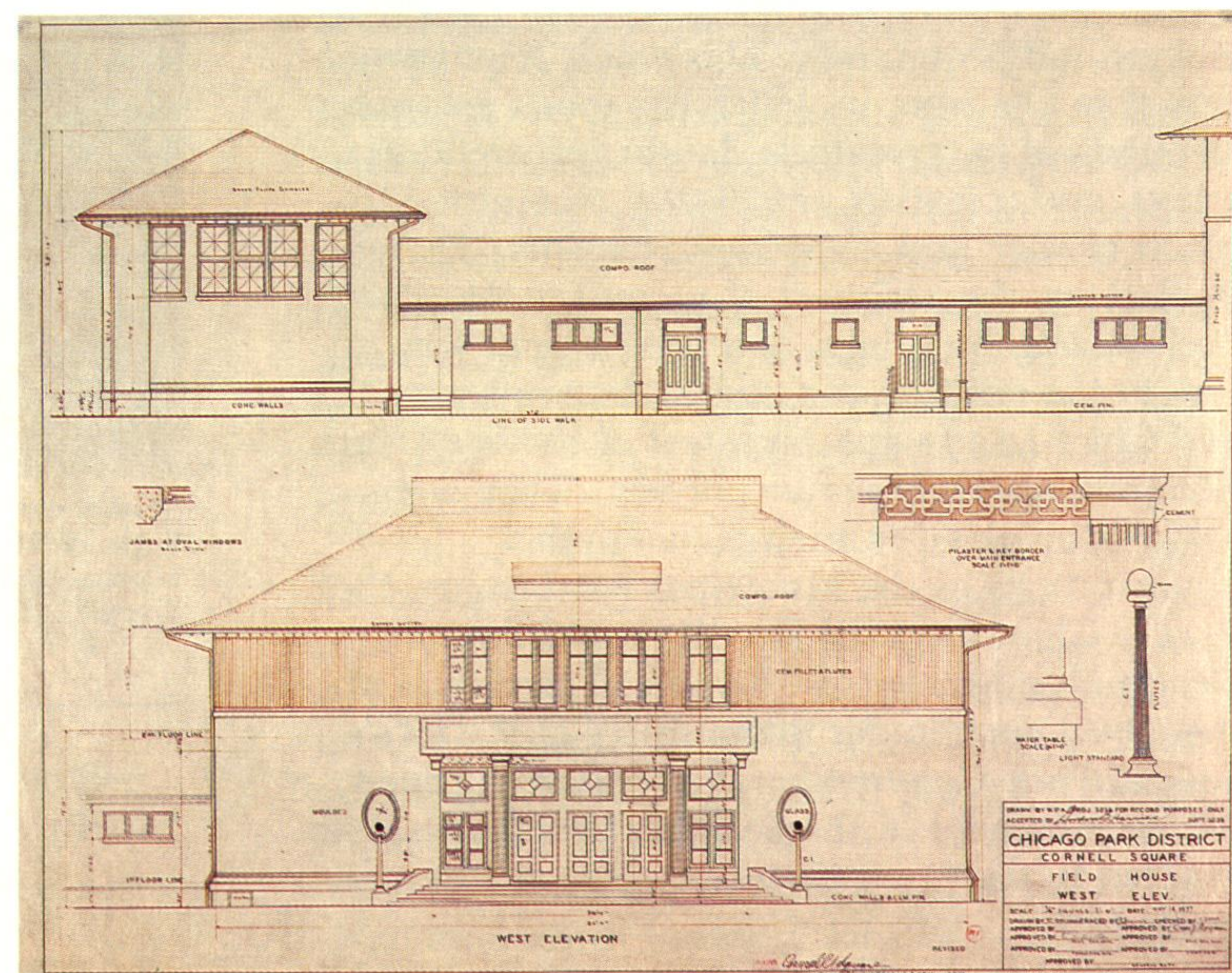
³Edith Abbot, *The Tenements of Chicago 1908-1935* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1936), p. 58.

⁴Honore Palmer, *Saturday Evening Post* (1901). Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District Special Collections.

⁵South Park Commission, *Annual Report* (1909), p. 37.

Drawing. Elevation of Cornell Square Fieldhouse, 1937. Chicago Park District Special Collections

During the period of the WPA, Chicago Park District staff surveyed existing architecture and created record drawings.



Parks, Playgrounds, and Progressivism

America entered the twentieth century confident and troubled. Prosperous at home and courting the idea of empire abroad, the nation seemed equal to any challenge. But its confidence would be tested by the unexpected side effects of progress: corporate trusts, which devoured competition; urban political machines, whose corruption mocked democratic processes; squalid tenements housing immigrants seeking the American dream; factories utilizing abundant and inexpensive child labor. These and other problems were graphically and insistently put before the American public by muckraking journalists, such as Ida Tarbell and Lincoln Steffens, in the day's mass market magazines.

The determination that poverty, corruption, greed, and injustice must not tarnish the American experiment led to one of this country's great eras of reform. Labeled "progressivism," it encompassed the first two decades of the twentieth century, when the American agenda was filled with proposals for change. Historians continue to debate the nature of progressivism, arguing over who the progressives were, whether their aims were altruistic or self-serving, and whether one can even speak of a unified progressive movement given the disparity of motives and goals.

Nevertheless, most historians agree upon certain unifying characteristics of the progressive era.¹ There was, first of all, an evangelical moralizing to progressive reform. The spirit of the revival animated reformers in their crusade against the sins of an unjust social order. A fitting theme song for progressivism might have been "Onward, Christian Soldiers!" Though most progressives had abandoned the structured religion of their parents, they continued to employ a vocabulary of Protestant uplift. Second, progressivism partook of the day's faith in science and social science. In practice, this meant an unswerving belief in the value of efficiency and the beneficent leadership of experts. Not only factories, but cities were to be run according to sound principles of management, as free as possible from the taint of politics.

Progressives, finally, shared a conviction



Books. *The Jungle* by Upton Sinclair, 1905, *If Christ Came to Chicago* by William T. Stead, 1894, and *The Spirit of Youth and the City Streets* by Jane Addams, 1909.

The Chicago Public Library Special Collections Department

Popular books of the period expressed great concern over the deplorable conditions under which a large portion of Chicago's population lived and worked.

that American society was fundamentally sound and that the problems it faced, though serious, were solvable. Such confidence was grounded in their belief that careful manipulation of the environment could remedy undesirable social behavior. This creed (historian Paul Boyer has termed it "positive environmentalism") became the bedrock of progressivism's myriad reforms, from housing to recreation to city planning to industrial safety. Experts would identify the environmental problem, devise techniques for its solution, and with the help of an enlightened social elite, implement the plan.

Progressives repeatedly used two phrases that evoked the essence of their programs: "social justice" and "social control." Social justice bespoke society's obligation to provide a level of decent existence for all its members, particularly its young and its women. We take this responsibility for granted today. But it was novel to a generation rooted in the dominant individualism of the nineteenth century. Yet justice had to be tempered with control. Modern life's "wolfish struggle for personal success, its crimes, frauds, exploitation, and parasitism" required a network of restraints, sociologist E. A. Ross wrote in his 1901 classic *Social Control*. These controls need not be coercive, but preferably subtle and suggestive



Photograph. The Irondale playground, 1908.
The Chicago Public Library Special Collections Department

through a well-planned environment. Harnessing individual desire to the larger social will presented a challenge to progressives.

It was appropriate that turn-of-the-century Chicago became the great laboratory of urban progressivism. No city better displayed the raw edge of an emergent industrial order. A city that had rebuilt from the holocaust of 1871 by sheer force of will, Chicago was still in its formative years, plastic enough to be molded by the architects of reform. Its boastful and self-aggrandizing nature (one recalls that its moniker "the Windy City" referred not to weather, but to self-promotion) betrayed a tender civic pride. But that very pride prompted city fathers to undertake the most ambitious program of civic betterment America had seen.

Chicago's cultural accomplishments of the late nineteenth century were impressive in both scope and quality. The Chicago Symphony Orchestra, Field Museum of Natural History, the University of Chicago, The Art Institute, and the Newberry and Crerar libraries were among the metropolis's monuments to civilization. Frederick Law Olmsted's Jackson and Washington Parks on the South Side were among the great landscaped public areas in the country. The city's aesthetic rehabilitation continued with Daniel Burnham's Chicago plan of 1909, which sought to bring the ordered environment of Chicago's 1893 Columbian Exposition to the rest of the city on a permanent basis.

But the progressive spirit was concerned less with these artifacts of high culture than with life a few blocks west of the Loop on Halsted Street or down in Packingtown. Burnham's vision of grand boulevards was here replaced by squalor, disease, and crime. In such neighborhoods would Chicago's conscience be tested. Park reform comprised an important part of

Chicago's moral reply. Modest in size, but lofty in purpose, the small parks and playgrounds represented a nearly perfect distillation of progressivism, and their beginnings provide an unequalled case study of that movement.²

At the turn of the century, the playground for most city children was the streets. Innocent games frequently gave way to baiting policemen and stealing from push-carts while trying to avoid the wheels of passing wagons. Reformers sought to redeem children from the streets by providing a venue of wholesome recreation. But getting urban leaders to see the need was the first step. Jacob Riis, whose classic photographic expose *How the Other Half Lives* focused national attention on the slums of New York, also campaigned actively for inner-city playgrounds. Having encouraged early playground construction in New York City, he came to Chicago in 1898 and delivered two talks before local notables that built enthusiasm for the Chicago movement. "A boy robbed of his chance to play," Riis warned, "will not be an honest and effective man - you can't depend on him at the polls."³

Chicago's settlement houses had begun addressing the problem. These institutions of immigrant uplift - so typical of progressivism - were, in fact, home to the city's earliest playgrounds. Jane Addams' Hull House organized what may be considered America's first true playground in 1894. Other settlements, such as Graham Taylor's Chicago Commons, also established play areas, as did the Chicago Women's Club through its Vacation School Committee.

Other groups were also becoming involved. The Municipal Science Club, a local group of businessmen and professionals (including two figures soon to be important in the playground movement, architect Dwight H. Perkins and sociologist Charles Zueblin), surveyed Chicago's recreational facilities. As a result of the Club's recommendations to the City Council, Mayor Carter Harrison appointed a Special Park Commission "whose duty it was to study the needs of the densely populated central wards and recommend a concerted plan for a small park and playground system."⁴

The Special Park Commission had originally intended to implement its recommendations through the auspices of the City, and it had begun to do so. It had successfully "established five parks in 1900, and assumed the cost of maintaining a sixth."⁵ (Three were located on

city property, and three on property leased from philanthropists.) In 1901, however, the City decreased the Commission's annual budget of \$100,000 to a total of \$11,500, and it was forced to redefine its role. While it attempted to continue creating additional parks and playgrounds on its minimal budget, the Special Park Commission decided to also work with the three existing park systems to achieve its ultimate goal. The South, West, and Lincoln Park Commissions had recently been enabled to begin establishing neighborhood parks through an act which had been presented to the State Legislature by such prominent Chicagoans as Philip Armour. The park systems relied heavily upon data compiled by the Special Park Commission to select sites for the new parks.

The South Park Commission became a major force behind Chicago's national leadership in playground development. General Superintendent J. Frank Foster envisioned, as early as 1895, a series of parks that would provide recreational and social facilities to dispel the dispiriting effects of urban blight as well as areas for rest and relaxation. Beginning in 1903, the South Park Commission planned neighborhood parks containing playgrounds throughout the south side. These were named for the giants of Chicago's industrial and commercial history: Paul Cornell, Philip Armour, Henry Ogden, and Potter Palmer, among others.

The well-publicized success of these

neighborhood parks encouraged the West Park and Lincoln Park Commissions to follow the South Park Commission's lead, though on a smaller scale. "The fundamental truth regarding park building is that it cannot be overdone," editorialized the *Chicago Record-Herald*.⁶ By 1916, scattered throughout Chicago were 55 playgrounds or neighborhood parks which had been created by the Park Commissions, the City, settlement houses, or other social agencies. Like The Chicago Public Library's decision to take its books to the people through neighborhood branch libraries, neighborhood parks represented an instrumentalist approach to public service.⁷

The physical construction of the new parks was only half of the story. The other half involved elaborating a philosophy of play and its benefits for America's future. Play — far from being a trivial activity for children — was imbued with special significance by progressives as they battled to save the collective body and soul of a nation. To that end, what occurred on the playgrounds was a matter of earnest supervision.

The importance of childhood play for healthy adult development found its most influential theoretician in G. Stanley Hall, a leading American psychologist of the late-nineteenth century. Hall believed that as children advance through distinct stages of life, they recapitulate the evolutionary development of humanity. Play — a "rehearsing of racial



Photograph. Mark White Square "Women's Gymnasium" apparatus. The Lawrence Company, photographer, ca. 1910.
Chicago Park District Special Collections

history" — enabled children to replicate the species' pre-civilized activities. Play was especially important in modern times, Hall asserted, because it aided cognitive development and instilled desirable moral habits. Hall worried that the enervating effects of urban life induced a physical and moral flabbiness in children. This danger could be offset in playgrounds, where primitive instincts could find a necessary outlet in play.⁸

Hall's primitivism struck a responsive chord among many of that age. Jane Addams believed that every boy "unconsciously uses ancient war-cries in his street play" and "longs to reproduce" the "values and vengeance" of a more primitive society.⁹ Similar allusions were made for the outdoor activities of the Boy Scouts, an organization founded in 1910. And there was the great popularity of Jack London's *The Call of the Wild*, a work explicitly built upon the cult of the primitive. The fear that America had become soft haunted people such as Theodore Roosevelt and William James. Roosevelt urged Americans on to a "strenuous life," even if that meant war. James sought a more cautionary path through a "moral equivalent of war" that might inculcate the same traits.

But playground advocates did not trust children to develop their own games. Contemporary play surveys discovered that unsupervised children abandoned cooperative play for "fighting, teasing, pitching pennies, shooting craps. . . [or] just fooling."¹⁰ Consequently, the play literature repeatedly

stressed the need for play leaders. Such individuals, some insisted, should have a training and status equal to social workers. These "chemists of human desire," as the recreation director for the South Park System's playgrounds phrased it, were to evoke the finer qualities of youth. Gymnasium instructors were exhorted to "Regard your work as an instrument with which to build character and good citizens . . . praise every tendency of a boy or girl to sacrifice himself or herself for the good of the team." Playground leaders were "engaged in a work which, if properly conducted, is perhaps better calculated to raise the standard of good citizenship than any other single agency in the hands of public servants."¹¹ Moralistic and self-assured, play reformers reflected prevailing attitudes of progressivism.

The demand for play leaders and careful playground organization betrayed two other typically progressive qualities: efficiency and the belief in experts. The rhetoric of playground construction and operation frequently invoked an industrial concern for efficiency. "Playgrounds acquired and operated without good business forethought and methods," stated South Park gymnastic supervisor E. B. DeGroot, "will turn out products no better than have been turned out by the street and alley playgrounds since the beginning of the city."¹² The insistence on expert leadership for playgrounds resulted in many cities requiring certifying exams of their workers.

The effort to construct, staff, and publicize playgrounds became an extensive social

movement requiring organizational support. This came with the founding of the Playground Association of America (PAA) in 1906. Its leaders, Luther H. Gulick Jr., Henry Curtis, and Joseph Lee, brought to the playground movement the complex blend of qualities that defined much of the play effort: a psychological interest in childhood development (Curtis was a student of G. Stanley Hall); a moral earnestness about character formation (Gulick was a missionary's son and former YMCA worker); a patrician concern for ensuring good government (Lee was a philanthropist and founder of the Massachusetts Civic League); and a belief that physical and social skills learned on the playground would create stronger citizens for the future. Funded by the reform-minded Russell Sage Foundation, the PAA publicized the cause of play through its journal *Playground*, undertook urban surveys of leisure time use, and encouraged establishment of playground associations in every major city.¹³

The PAA planned its first national convention for Chicago in 1907. President Theodore Roosevelt, himself an honorary member of the PAA, encouraged delegates from other cities to come to Chicago and attend the meetings. Preparing to host the meeting, local playground activists organized the Chicago Playground Association (CPA). As a voluntary auxiliary to the park boards' work, the CPA investigated where playgrounds were needed, sought to stimulate grass-roots support for local playgrounds, and acquired vacant lots for their location.

The eighteen directors of the CPA represented a cross-section of Chicago's reforming elite. Progressive businessmen such as Harold McCormick and Livingston Wells Fargo belonged. Professionals joined as well, like well-known Juvenile Court Judge Julian Mack and noted landscape architect Jens Jensen (who also served as superintendent for the West Side park system). And, not surprisingly, leaders from Chicago's social work community also served: Jane Addams, Mary McDowell, and Henry Thurston among them. The playground movement was also the direct beneficiary of Chicago philanthropists. Anita McCormick Blaine, one of the city's most active philanthropic reformers, served as a CPA director, and the McCormick family donated to the city a lot on the West Side to be developed for play. The Commercial Club, Chicago's most prestigious gathering of businessmen, raised \$10,000 to buy another playground site.¹⁴

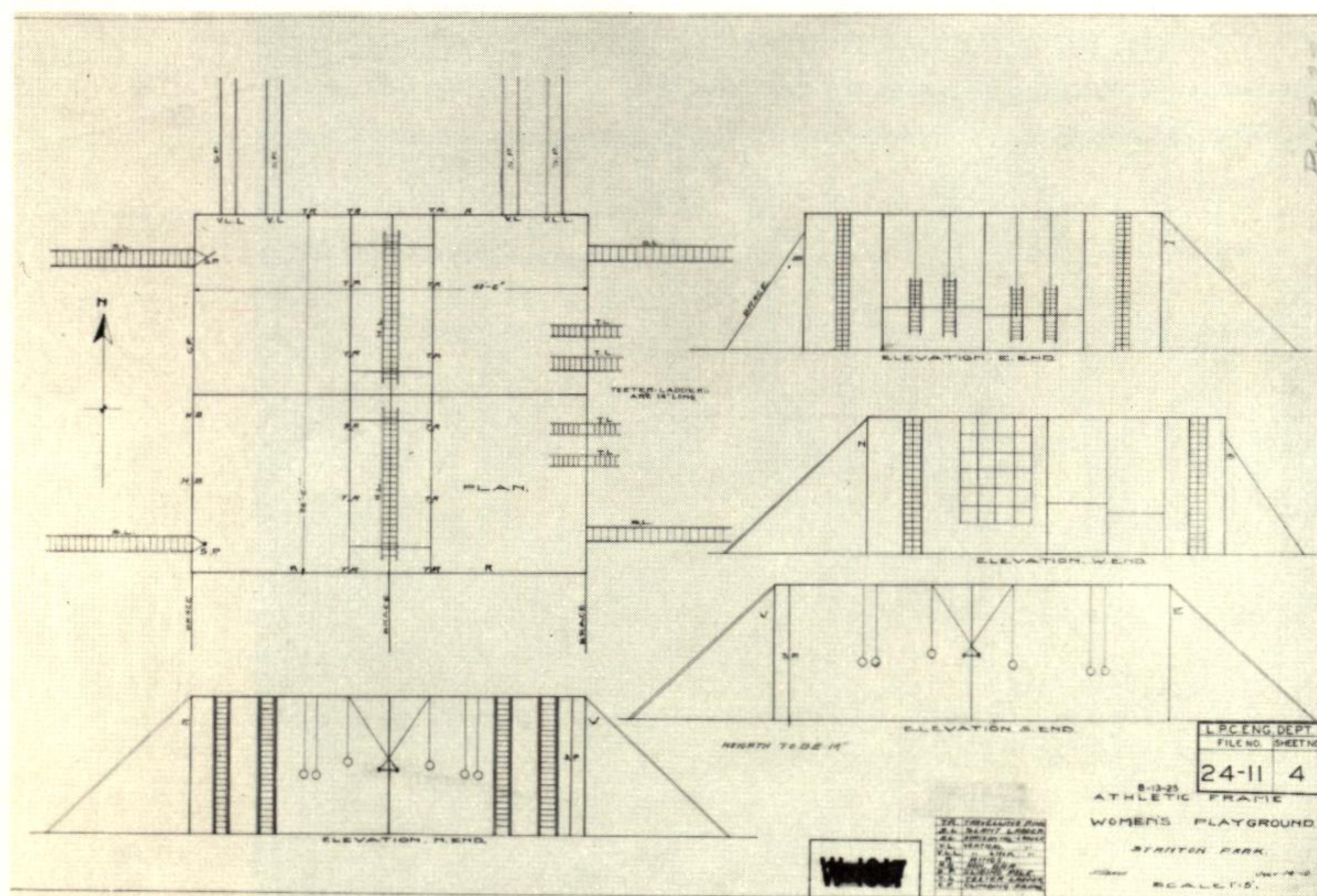
The multiple benefits of this effort were enumerated at the PAA's first national conference, held in Chicago during a few festive

June days in 1907. The papers delivered — and even more the group activities in which all were involved — summed up the spirit and philosophy of the movement. "There wasn't a minute when the play spirit even took a rest," Graham Romeyn Taylor exulted. "It romped in at the Thursday night session . . . And it romped boisterously out late on Saturday afternoon when a whole field of 5,000 delegates, spectators and festival participants played tag with a thunderstorm."¹⁵

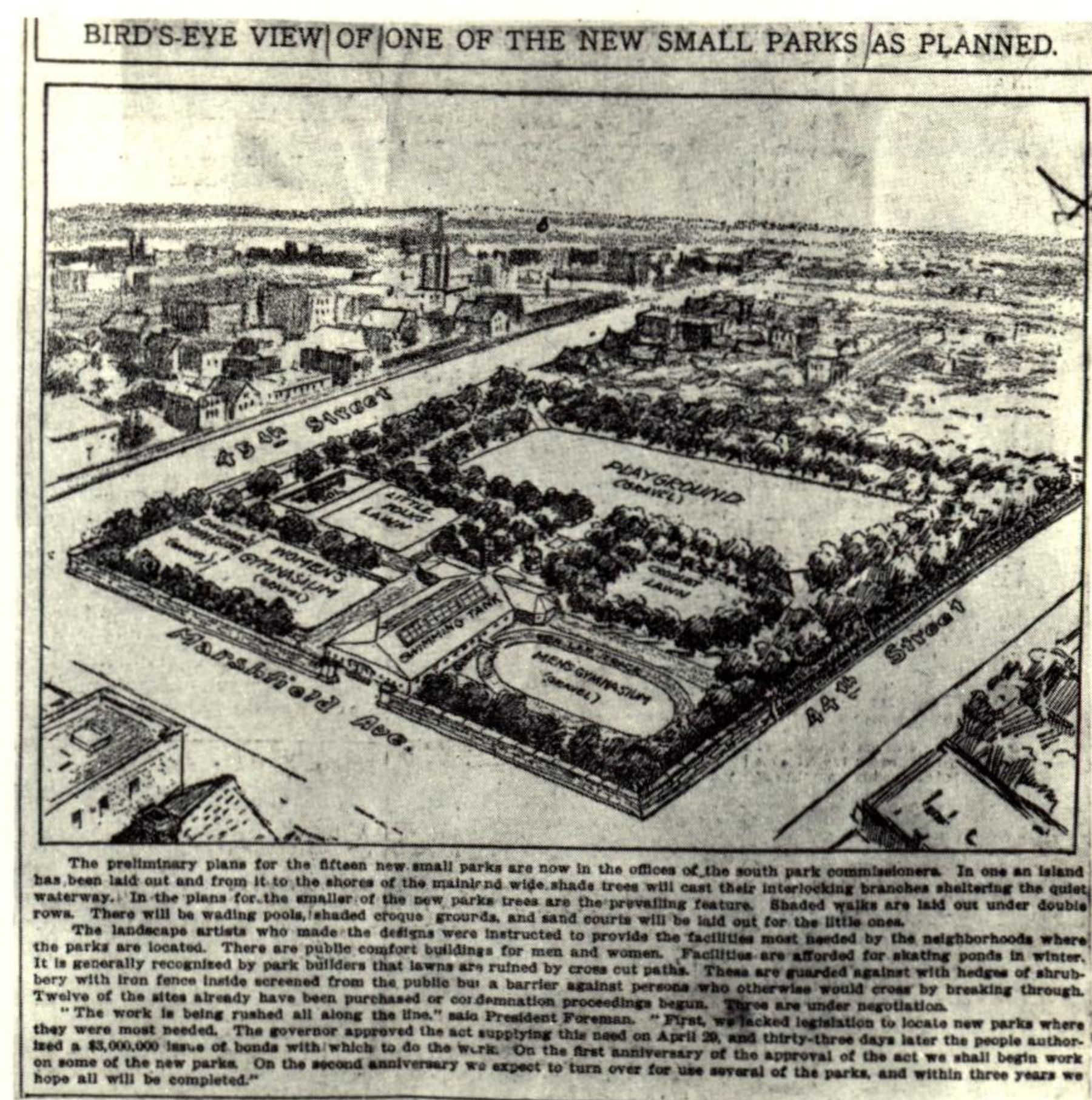
The playground movement truly became a coordinated national effort at the Chicago meeting. Delegates from thirty cities met to compare problems and exchange strategies regarding their recreational needs. They heard papers on the techniques of playground administration and on the social benefits of play. Titles reveal their social philosophy of play: "Play as a School of the Citizen," "Public Recreation and Social Morality," "Relation of Play to Juvenile Delinquency," and "Playgrounds in the Prevention of Tuberculosis." PAA President Luther Gulick's address, "Play and Democracy," articulated characteristically progressive hopes for the influence of play. Small children on the sand pile, he said, "learn fundamental lessons in mutual rights." Older children learn similar lessons "by sharing the use of swings, by having to play by the rules of the game." Team games instill self-sacrifice and demonstrate that the "social unit is larger than the individual." Ultimately, the child will realize that "the most perfect self-realization is won by the most perfect sinking of one's self in the welfare of the larger unit — the team. Thus the child learns to control himself in these increasingly complex relationships."¹⁶ Progressive reformers, for whom the modern city represented a massive breakdown of older moral controls, saw in supervised play the opportunity to reclaim America's youth.

Chicago's South Park system of small parks was intended not only for children, but also as a complete recreation center for families and neighborhoods. The fieldhouses held assembly halls and clubrooms, gymnasias, branch public libraries, and outdoor swimming pools. These were intended to complement the work of the social settlements by providing venues of family and community building in the impersonal and frequently hostile city. "When the family splits up for its recreation, there is danger," warned Chicago social worker Amalie Hofer Jerome. "Only when the family stays together do we have wholesome conditions."¹⁷

Just as reformers hoped that playgrounds would strengthen family ties, they expected them



Drawing. Athletic frame for the women's playground in Stanton Park. Lincoln Park District Engineering Department, 1910. Chicago Park District Special Collections



Newspaper article. Chicago Tribune, February 5, 1904. From the newspaper clippings volumes assembled by the Lincoln Park Commissioners. Chicago Park District Special Collections



Photograph. Children wading in a mud puddle in an empty lot at 45th and Laflin Streets, ca. 1900.
Chicago Historical Society

to unify the diverse tide of immigrants. National and racial prejudices would melt in the warmth of shared activities. But playground advocates did not preach a nativistic brand of forced Americanism. They accepted Jane Addams' dictum that immigrants ought "to preserve and keep whatever of value their past life contained."¹⁸ Thus, play leaders sought to nurture children in their ethnic heritage through their homeland's music, costumed folk dancing, and national games, which were prominently featured at the Chicago convention and continued in later play festivals.

Did the playground movement accomplish its goals? In large measure, that question remains unanswerable. We can only speculate about, rather than prove, organized play's effect on patriotism, democracy, morals, or family life. Lacking the progressives' confidence in environmental remedies, we tend to be skeptical of their enthusiastic claims. But if playgrounds failed to cure the social ills of the city, they succeeded in offering recreational amenities the urban poor had never before known. Chicago neighborhoods became better places to live because of the presence of a Marquette or a Hamlin Park. And Chicago's children — blithely unaware of the sociological meaning with which adults freighted their games — found sanctuary for their simple pleasures.

¹ Recent important studies of progressivism include Paul Boyer, *Urban Masses and Moral Order in America, 1820-1920* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1978); Richard L. McCormick, *The Party Period and Public Policy: American Politics from the Age of Jackson to the Progressive Era* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1986); Robert Crunden, *Ministers of Reform* (New York: Basic Books, 1982).

² The history of Chicago's playground movement is drawn largely from Benjamin McArthur's "The Chicago Playground Movement: A Neglected Feature of Social Justice," *Social Service Review* 49 (September 1975): 376-395.

³ *Chicago Record-Herald*, 12 November 1899.

⁴ Uncited newspaper (September 1901). Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

⁵ Michael P. McCarthy, "Politics and the Parks: Chicago Businessmen and the Recreation Movement," *Journal of the Illinois State Historical Society* 65 (1972): 163.

⁶ *Chicago Record-Herald*, 6 June 1906.

⁷ Helen Lefkowitz Horowitz, *Culture and the City: Cultural Philanthropy in Chicago From the 1880s to 1917* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 1976).

⁸ Dominick Cavallo, *Muscles and Morals: Organized Playgrounds and Urban Reform, 1880-1920* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1981).

⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 75.

¹⁰ George E. Johnson, *Education Through Recreation* (Cleveland: The Survey Committee of the Cleveland Foundation, 1916).

¹¹ Quoted in McArthur, "The Chicago Playground Movement."

¹² E.B. DeGroot, "Recent Playground Development in Chicago," *Proceedings of the 2nd Annual Playground Congress and Yearbook*, New York, September 8-12, 1908, p. 153.

¹³ Cavallo, pp. 32-38.

¹⁴ A.W. Beilfuss, "Municipal Playgrounds in Chicago," *Proceedings of the 2nd Annual Playground Congress and Yearbook*, New York, September 8-12, 1908, pp. 258-259.

¹⁵ Graham Romeyn Taylor, "How They Played at Chicago," *Papers of the Chicago Meeting, Playground Association of America*, June 1907.

¹⁶ Luther Halsey Gulick, "Play and Democracy," *Papers of the Chicago Meeting, Playground Association of America*, June 1907.

¹⁷ Quoted in McArthur, "The Chicago Playground Movement."

¹⁸ Jane Addams, *Twenty Years at Hull-House* (New York: Signet Books, 1960), p. 169.

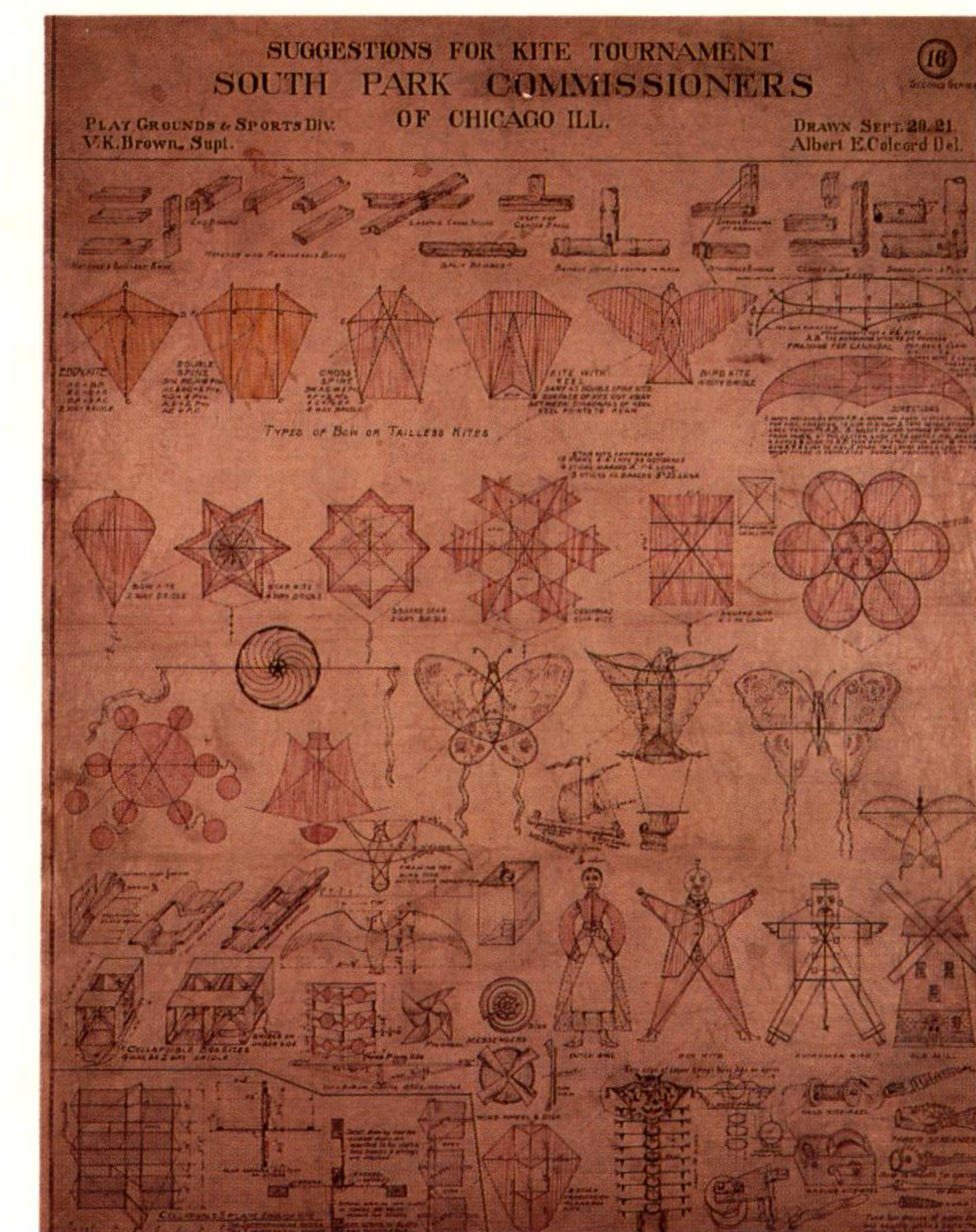
Parks for the People

Chicago at the turn of the century epitomized the American industrial city. Its streets were filled not only with the noise of commerce, but also with the languages of every part of Europe and most of the world. By 1901, the foreign-born and their children made up roughly seventy-seven percent of Chicago's population.¹ In the tradition of laissez-faire society, economic development occurred in a rather haphazard manner. As no city policies regarding zoning had yet emerged, housing and industrial structures were rapidly built in the same areas. The city's well-to-do did not live in these districts. They enjoyed the beautiful boulevard and park systems, and the Lake Michigan winds freshened their neighborhoods. The poor, however, lived in wooden slums next to smoky factories and the Union Stock Yards. Raw sewage ran along the muddy, unpaved streets. Few people had access to bathing facilities or health care. Lake Michigan and the parks were far away.

Chicago's slums attracted the attention of progressive reformers who saw them as a challenge to the American way of life. Jane Addams, Mary McDowell, Graham Taylor, and other pioneers of the settlement house movement tied the issues of disease, crime, and even machine politics to the living conditions of those who formed Chicago's industrial army. They believed that the development of playgrounds and parks provided one answer to the slum and its problems.

In 1898, Charles Zueblin of the University of Chicago published an influential article in *The American Journal of Sociology* which outlined Chicago's social problems and presented the idea of playgrounds as one possible solution. Zueblin pointed out that the unique boulevard and park systems were inadequate for the industrial city that had developed since Frederick Law Olmsted had begun work on the South Park System in 1869. By the turn of the century, the city sorely lagged behind eastern cities in the amount of park space and the services those parks provided, especially to the poor.

Zueblin called for an intricate system of small parks and playgrounds in Chicago's



Drawing. Suggestions for a kite tournament. Albert E. Colcord, South Park Commission, 1921.
Chicago Park District Special Collections

industrial neighborhoods. The professor made the point that between 600,000 and 700,000 Chicagoans lived in areas unserved by the city's system of parks. They also lived in some of the most crowded districts in urban America.² Settlement house playgrounds and a few public school playgrounds provided some services to the city's industrial river wards, but generally speaking, those areas remained underserved. Alfred Tennyson Lloyd, a graduate student at Northwestern University, completed a study of Chicago's parks in 1901, and like Zueblin, pointed to the problems of the river wards. Lloyd explained that three social classes could not use the parks easily — the very young, the very old, and the very poor.³

While nothing had yet happened on a comprehensive level, social reformers continued the effort to establish playgrounds in some of the most crowded areas in the city. In August, 1901, *The Chicago Tribune* detailed the opening of Holden Playground in the Bridgeport neighborhood.⁴ The *Inter-Ocean* reported in August of 1902 that the Mosely Playground on 24th and Wabash was a remarkable achievement. A photograph with the news article showed black and white children playing together on the playground.⁵

While the new playgrounds were receiving a great deal of use and good publicity, there was some debate about whether neighborhood parks

should be playgrounds or spaces for passive relaxation. Jane Addams' view on the matter was that the playground was the most important component of any new park:

If there is to be any conflict as to which use shall be made of the land, there is no doubt at all in my mind that it should be decided in favor of the playgrounds. The adults can get almost as much good out of playgrounds as the children, while the children get the good from the parks. If the grass and trees are to be carefully preserved, the children must still be made to play in the streets.⁶

When the South Park Commission created McKinley Park, their first neighborhood park, they used it to test their idea of combining the features advocated by those who wanted playgrounds and those who wanted parks for passive relaxation. The park became the centerpiece for the whole new neighborhood park movement.

McKinley Park was the first new park to develop on the new Southwest Side near the Union Stock Yards. On property which had previously been the Brighton Race Track, it stood at the intersection of Archer and Western Avenues. After the race track closed, the property had become the site of cabbage fields, truck farms, and prairie. The *Chicago Tribune* reported that the South Park Commission was turning an eyesore into a garden spot, bringing beauty as well as utility into the working-class district.⁷

The new park included a swimming pool, changing rooms, and a bath house. For many area residents, the park offered the only bathing facilities available to them. Ultimately, more than 121,000 people used the pool in one year alone. Children made good use of the wading pool, even before the 35-acre park officially opened on June 13, 1902. Some 10,000 people attended the dedication ceremonies for the opening of McKinley Park.⁸ Henry G. Foreman, an organizer of the Chicago Stock Exchange and the Chicago Real Estate Board, was President of the South Park Commission's Board of Commissioners. In his address at the McKinley Park dedication, he declared that the opening of McKinley Park marked the beginning of a new era in park construction: "Two years ago it was a cabbage patch, and the change made here in that short time shows what can be done in rapid park building."⁹ The park was immensely successful. Because of its intensive use and the growing density of the area, the South Park Commission more than doubled its size within two years of its official opening.

The neighborhood surrounding McKinley

Park was a working-class community made up primarily of German, Scandinavian, Irish, and Polish residents. In 1909, most of these workers labored in the meatpacking and steel plants located just to the east of the community. Many also worked for the railroads which entered the city from the southwest. Living conditions in the McKinley Park area were perhaps the best in the neighborhoods touching on the Union Stock Yards, but here, too, the wooden tenement and the outhouse existed next to more modern facilities.¹⁰

Just to the south of McKinley Park lay the Back of the Yards neighborhood. This area was the one most closely identified with the meatpacking industry. In 1906, Upton Sinclair published *The Jungle*, a novel that portrayed the living and working conditions in the area.

The meatpacking industry dominated the Back of the Yards community. Huge smokestacks with billowing clouds of thick black smoke created an industrial skyline to the east. To the west lay large open garbage dumps that cut the community off from the prairies at the edge of the city. Railroad tracks entered the stockyards to the south of the neighborhood. Bubbly Creek, a polluted fork of the South Branch of the Chicago River, formed its northern boundary along with a massive collection of packinghouse buildings that seemed to overflow from the stockyard itself. The smells of the packinghouses dominated the neighborhood.¹¹

Small wooden frame tenements made up most of the neighborhood's housing stock. The typical structure was a two-flat containing two, four-to-six-room apartments. To the casual observer, the district might not seem crowded. The problem of congestion in the small apartments, however, was real. While the neighborhood contained a good deal of open space in the form of front and back yards, the small apartments frequently housed far too many people. Unsanitary conditions often prevailed in the slaughterhouses and in the neighborhood. Investigators claimed that the influence of the giant packinghouses was degrading.¹²

Immigrants and their families filled the neighborhood, which by 1900 had taken on a definitely East European flavor. These various groups established their own churches, schools, taverns, and fraternal institutions. The children of the neighborhood played in the streets and on the empty lots which dotted the residential blocks. Adults often congregated on the front steps of the tenements on warm Chicago nights.¹³

Back of the Yards was typical of the type of

neighborhood that Zueblin, Lloyd, and Jane Addams had in mind when they called for a neighborhood parks program. Different industries dominated other neighborhoods, such as steel in South Chicago or tanneries and other smaller businesses along the North Branch of the Chicago River. Often the housing and sanitary conditions in these wards were comparable.

The populations also had much in common. Though perhaps of different ethnicity or race, they were frequently new to Chicago and even to the industrial world. They also seemed to be isolated from the mainstream of American life in their ethnic enclaves. The districts frequently suffered from gang activities and high crime rates. Many middle-class Americans perceived the crowded industrial quarters not only as impoverished districts, but because of foreign cultures, labor strikes, and occasional radical political activities, threats to the American way of life.¹⁴

The location of the new parks in these industrial neighborhoods presented a controversy throughout the period of the development of the new park system. Politics always remained a factor in site selection, but the three major park districts eventually settled on sites, with the South Park Commission leading the way. In 1902, a report recommended fourteen South Side sites from which eleven were to be chosen. Four were to be selected in the stockyard district alone.¹⁵

Land acquisition in such densely populated districts was not an easy matter for the park commissions. The West Park Commissioners picked a location in the heavily crowded West Town District near the North Branch of the Chicago River that required the removal of many tenements. While the commissioners declared the property was worth \$200,000, the owners, Mr. and Mrs. Charles T. Boal, claimed

the land was worth twice that amount. The Boals owned all of the acreage and rented it to the owners of tenements who had erected buildings on the lots. Charles Boal claimed an annual income of \$9,900 from the property. The West Park Commissioners, nevertheless, were able to acquire the future site of Eckhart Park.¹⁶

In February 1904, the *Chicago Tribune* printed an artist's rendition of Davis Square, one of the neighborhood parks to be opened in Back of the Yards the following summer. Davis Square provided a prime example of the neighborhood park. Only about one-quarter the size of McKinley Park, Davis Square did not include lavish landscaping nor did it have a lagoon like the larger playground. Nevertheless, it offered most of the amenities asked for by reformers. The fieldhouse was the centerpiece of the park and made Davis Square a year-round neighborhood center. The building contained gymnasiums, showers, meeting rooms, a library, and even a cafeteria. Soap and towels were provided for free, and the meals were provided at cost. Doctors and nurses volunteered their time, providing much-needed free health care. The fieldhouses were designed to be municipally maintained community centers. Indeed, the Chicago fieldhouse presented a model for parks all over the nation.¹⁷

On May 13, 1905, the South Park Commissioners opened Davis Square Park. A crowd of about 4,000 attended the opening ceremonies which included a dedication speech by Henry G. Foreman. The entire ceremony had been orchestrated by Mary McDowell, the resident head of the nearby University of Chicago settlement house. Foreman proclaimed Davis Square to be the settlement ideal applied to parks. His speech went on to outline the social theory behind Davis Square and all of the



Photograph. Workingmen's housing, ca. 1910.
Chicago Historical Society

In the first decade of the twentieth century, Chicago's population doubled from one to two million. This increase strained the services of the city. The poor were crowded into frame tenement houses.

neighborhood parks of the period:

When you people who live in this part of Chicago come home tired at night, or when you have a holiday, or when you are tempted to do something wrong, come over here and listen to the music. Come and see your children work in the gymnasium; come and take a bath or swim, or see the trees and flowers.... If there is anything about this district you don't like, call a meeting in this room and talk it over. Use this assembly hall freely for any good purpose, except for religious or political meetings.

Other notables also spoke to the group. John Smulski, the well-known Polish banker and politician, addressed the heavily Slavic crowd. Later, the Polish and Bohemian Turners entertained the assembly with gymnastic feats.¹⁸

The intent of the reformers was symbolized in the organization of the parks. Control was very centralized, and park personnel regulated activities tightly. They arranged gymnastics and various types of sports around strict rules of competition. Park supervisors established baseball and softball leagues. The intent of both the recreational and hygiene facilities was to create a new kind of industrial resident. As one newspaper proclaimed, out of the slums would come "clean, healthy men and women." This was thought to be in sharp contrast to the realities of the industrial districts.¹⁹

The parks quickly became neighborhood centers. Numerous classes were taught in the fieldhouses. Many of these offered skills which could provide immigrants with vocations including woodworking, the millinery business, and other handicrafts. Clubs and organizations also met in the fieldhouses. The West Park System was particularly interested in promoting social and educational activities. It developed the idea of community gardens in the neighborhood parks. These gardens yielded so much produce that the excess vegetables were donated to orphanages and other charities.

The new parks also provided a public place to celebrate and attend classes and lectures. Folk dancing provided some of the entertainment. So did plays, dances, and movies. These activities were often of a decidedly American flavor. The assimilation of the various ethnic groups was a goal of the park designers and reformers. During and after World War One, this became very apparent; park commissioners literally handed the parks over to the YMCA for Americanization classes. Davis Square, Dvorak Park, McKinley Park, and Seward Park, among others, all provided Americanization courses. Over 1,000,000 Chicagoans attended these classes and lectures.²⁰

While park supervisors had specific plans for how the parks should be used, their location in the middle of working-class neighborhoods meant that they might also be used as centers for various kinds of protests and gatherings. Davis Square, situated just outside the gates of the city's major packinghouses, soon became a rallying point for union organizers. On March 31, 1918, Easter Sunday, a crowd of about 40,000 packinghouse workers and their families gathered in the park to hear the announcement of the arbitration award granted by Judge Samuel Alschuler between the Amalgamated Meat Cutters and the packing companies. John Kikulski, the Polish labor leader, and John Fitzpatrick of the Chicago Federation of Labor, addressed the multi-ethnic and inter-racial crowd.²¹ Neighborhood residents obviously were taking the advice given by Henry G. Foreman in 1905 to use the parks to discuss local problems. The South Park Commissioners, however, soon cut down on such activities. In 1919, they would not allow steel workers to hold a strike rally at Bessemer Park in South Chicago. The union simply moved the assembly to a nearby street corner and then to a hall donated by local



Woman's bathing suit, all wool jumpsuit with a detachable skirt, ca. 1910.
Highland Park Historical Society

Typically, the swimming tanks and showers in the neighborhood parks were the only available bathing facilities in the area. Free soap and towels were provided by the park districts.



Photograph. Kite making by a group of boys in one of the neighborhood park fieldhouses for the annual kite-flying contest. From *Chicago's Great South Shore*, John C. Spray, editor, 1910.
The Chicago Public Library Special Collections Department

merchants.²² In 1921, Davis Square became the center of yet another labor struggle.

In the aftermath of the First World War, the major packing companies moved against the union. This resulted in a strike that began on December 5, 1921. The area surrounding Davis Square soon became the scene of an armed struggle between the striking packinghouse workers and the Chicago police. On December 8, 1921, the northeast corner of the park at 44th and Marshfield saw a major confrontation between the police and a crowd of Polish women holding their children. The police

searched door-to-door on Marshfield Street looking for guns and ammunition.²³

The parks in the working-class districts continued to be the focal points of much community activity even after the labor struggles of the World War One period had ended. In 1930, Davis Square became the first headquarters of the Back of the Yards Neighborhood Council founded by Saul Alinsky and the then park supervisor Joseph Meegan. Russell Square, near the gates of U.S. Steel's South Works, gave its name to the Russell Square Community Committee, also organized in the 1930s.²⁴

The neighborhood parks provided much-needed public space in Chicago's working-class districts. Social reformers saw them as a way of solving some of the problems of the inner-city, and perhaps of assimilating and controlling the immigrant masses who lived and worked in these neighborhoods. In reality, the parks, with their well-organized programs and good facilities, fulfilled a real need in the neighborhoods and became a central part of them. They may not have played the role that their creators had originally hoped for, but they acted as a dynamic force in the creation of a sense of community in the neighborhoods of Chicago.

Dominic Pacyga



Handkerchief, 1919.
The Chicago Public Library Sulzer Regional Library

The fieldhouse served as a community center for Chicago's many immigrant groups, providing a place where they could both display their ethnic pride and attend activities to learn about their new country.

¹ For the growth of Chicago as an industrial giant, see Harold M. Mayer and Richard C. Wade, *Chicago: Growth of a Metropolis* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1969). The best source for a look at the ethnic development of the city is the series of essays contained in Melvin J. Holli and Peter d'A. Jones, *Ethnic Chicago* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Eerdmanns Publishing Company, 1980).

² Charles Zueblin, "Municipal Playgrounds in Chicago," *The American Journal of Sociology* (September 1898): 146-148.

³ Alfred Tennyson Lloyd, "The History and Administration of the Public Parks in Chicago with Suggestions for Making Them More Useful," excerpted in an uncited newspaper from the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

⁴ *Chicago Tribune*, 25 August 1901. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

⁵ *Inter-Ocean*, 22 August 1902. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

⁶ *Chicago Record-Herald*, 1 June 1902. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

⁷ *Chicago Tribune*, 30 August 1902. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

⁸ *Record-Herald*, 8 June 1903; *Chicago Journal*, 13 June 1903; *Record-Herald*, 14 June 1902. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

⁹ Works Progress Administration (WPA), *Historical Register of the Twenty-two Superceded Park Districts* (Chicago: Chicago Park District, 1941).

¹⁰ Dominic A. Pacyga and Ellen Skerrett, *Chicago: City of Neighborhoods* (Chicago: Loyola University Press, 1986), pp. 459-464.

¹¹ James R. Barrett, *Work and Community in the Jungle: Chicago's Packinghouse Workers, 1894-1922* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1987), pp. 66-73.

¹² Sophonisba Breckenridge and Edith Abbott, "Housing Conditions in Chicago III, Back of the Yards," *The American Journal of Sociology* (January 1911): 435, 441.

¹³ For a description of the Polish community in the stockyard district, see Dominic A. Pacyga, "Villages of Steel Mills and Packinghouses: The Polish Worker on Chicago's South Side, 1880-1921." (Ph.D. Dissertation, University of Illinois at Chicago, 1981).

¹⁴ For a description of youth gangs and their locations in the working-class wards of Chicago during the 1920s, see Frederic M. Thrasher, *The Gang: A Study of 1,313 Gangs in Chicago* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1927).

¹⁵ *Chicago Tribune*, 26 October 1902. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

¹⁶ *Chicago Tribune*, 12 November 1902. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

¹⁷ Galen Cranz, *The Politics of Park Design: A History of Urban Parks in America* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: The MIT Press, 1984), p. 87.

¹⁸ *Chicago Tribune*, 14 May 1905. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes, Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

¹⁹ Uncited newspaper, undated. From the Lincoln Park Commission Newspaper Clippings Volumes (volume 3, page B), Chicago Park District, Special Collections.

²⁰ Robert Henry Becker, "Teaching Good Citizenship in Chicago's Parks and Playgrounds," *Fort Dearborn Magazine* (September 1920): 19-20.

²¹ Mary E. McDowell, "Easter Day After the Decision," *The Survey* (13 April 1918): 38.

²² *New Majority*, 4 October 1919.

²³ *Chicago Tribune*, 9 December 1921.

²⁴ For an overview of the development of these two neighborhood organizations, see Robert Slayton, *Back of the Yards: The Making of a Local Democracy* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1987); and Dominic A. Pacyga, "The Russell Square Community Committee: An Ethnic Response to Urban Problems," *Journal of Urban History* (February 1989): 159-184.

The Planning and Design of Chicago's Neighborhood Parks

Chicago's settlement house reformers can be credited not only with the conception of neighborhood centers to provide social services in the densely populated working class districts, but also with establishing the city's earliest playgrounds. Small properties were secured amidst crowded tenement housing to explore controlled, active recreation as a means of socializing and acculturating the immigrant children. The progressive reformers of the play movement put great thought into the components and programming of the new "breathing spaces." However, little effort was devoted to the design of these areas. Lots of sand or dirt, open or filled with heavy gymnastics apparatus, generally characterized the playgrounds. When Chicago's three Park Commissions joined the growing movement, they brought tremendous vision to the creation of their new "breathing spaces." In addition to integrating their own ideas with those of the settlement house reformers, the Park Commissions included major architects and landscape architects in the planning process. Ultimately, these Chicago efforts led to a revolutionary park form which influenced the way in which the parks developed throughout the United States.

Prior to an 1899 Act of State Legislation, the city's three original Park Commissions were not empowered to create parklands, in addition to those secured upon their inception in 1869.¹ In general, this meant that the existing parks consisted of Washington and Jackson Parks and the Midway Plaisance on Chicago's south side; Garfield, Douglas, and Humboldt Parks and interconnecting boulevards on the west; and Lincoln Park on the north side. Passive recreation and pastoral landscapes were the primary design elements in these large regional "pleasure grounds." They were picturesque landscapes composed of wide open meadows, winding paths, artificial lakes, masses of trees and shrubbery, music courts, and an occasional architectural folly. Frederick Law Olmsted, Sr., now considered the father of landscape architecture in America, was the designer of such "pleasure grounds" as New York's Central Park, and Washington and Jackson Parks and



Postcards. Clockwise from top right: Washington Park scene, Garfield Park flower beds, Washington Park sunken gardens and conservatory, Humboldt Park sunken garden, Lincoln Park view, Jackson Park wooden island, Lincoln Park promenade (center), ca. 1900-1920. Chicago Park District Special Collections

the Midway Plaisance in Chicago. He wrote that parks should encompass "the beauty of the fields, the meadow, the prairie and the still waters. What we want to gain is tranquility and rest to the mind."²

Olmsted envisioned "people's parks" to allow for friendly interaction between members of all classes and to provide an escape from urban tensions. By the end of the century, however, most of the city's working class residents did not have access to the existing parks, which were located on the perimeter of the city. Urban tensions had grown more intense than those which Olmsted had addressed. His idea of beautiful pastoral refuges was a passive means of social reform. However, by proposing "breathing spaces" within the neighborhoods, the settlement house reformers and playground advocates sought a more direct kind of influence. The South, West, and Lincoln Park Commissions drew from both approaches in the creation of a new park type - the neighborhood park.

The South Park Commission (SPC) was the first of three park systems to follow the City of Chicago Special Park Commission's appeal to establish parks in the congested tenement districts. In 1900, after the Special Park Commission had successfully lobbied for small parks legislation, the SPC began acquiring a 34-acre property near the stockyards on which to develop an experimental neighborhood park. Equipped with a swimming pool and changing rooms, ball fields, and playgrounds, McKinley Park officially opened in 1902. This project was guided by the General Superintendent, J. Frank Foster, who was largely responsible for the SPC's progressive attitude. He conceived of program components to be included in the new



Photograph. Mark White Square wading pool. The Lawrence Company, photographer, ca. 1905. Chicago Park District Special Collections